

Attitudes of *fear* and expletive negation in French

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Abstract

This paper examines the distribution of expletive negation (ExN) in French *fear*-clauses and proposes a refined ontology of *fear*-related attitudes. We argue that *fear*-predicates select two semantically distinct types of complements, cognitive and conative, reflecting two types of fears. Cognitive are truth-apt and exhibit a mind-to-world direction of fit, similar to beliefs. Conative fears, in contrast, resemble wishes or commands. They are realization-apt and exhibit a world-to-mind direction of fit instead. This distinction explains why some *fear*-clauses in French are truth-apt, whereas others can only be realized. Although *fear*-predicates can in principle introduce either type of complement, we argue that the syntax of the embedded clause constrains the choice. Specifically, the presence of ExN introduces an object of belief associated with the fear, enforcing a cognitive interpretation. In its absence, the embedded structure is understood to be conative. Our proposal has two cross-linguistic implications. First, languages may realize distinct *fear* objects differently (e.g., English). Second, we predict structural variation in embedded clauses under *fear*, depending on their semantic type (e.g., Turkish).

Keywords: expletive negation, *fears*, French, ontology, attitudes, truthmaker semantics

30 1 Introduction

31 In this paper, we revisit the semantic nature of French *fear*-predicates, like *craindre*
 32 and *avoir peur* in relation to so-called “expletive” *ne* (cf. Müller 1978; Larrivée 1994;
 33 Rowlett 1998a among others).¹ Traditionally, this marker is considered to have no
 34 impact on the interpretation of the clause it appears in.² Consequently, its presence
 35 is also considered optional (Muller 1978), as is illustrated by means of the examples
 36 in (1).³ In (1a), the embedded clause involves the so-called expletive negation (EXN)
 37 while in (1b), it is absent. Despite this small formal difference, the two sentences seem
 38 to have the same interpretation in terms of polarity. That is, both embedded sentences
 39 are understood to be affirmative. This contrasts sharply with the example in (1c),
 40 where in addition to an optional *ne*, the negative marker *pas* turns the embedded
 41 sentence into a negative one. Note in passing that the embedded predicates in (1) all
 42 have subjunctive mood.

- 43 (1) a. Je crains que Marie **ne** parte.
 44 I fear that Marie (EXN) leave.SBJV
 45 ‘I fear that Marie would leave.’
 46 b. Je crains que Marie $\emptyset$ parte.
 47 I fear that Marie $\emptyset$ leave.SBJV
 48 ‘I fear that Marie would leave.’
 49 c. Je crains que Marie (**ne**) parte pas.
 50 I fear that Marie (EXN) leave.SBJV NEG
 51 ‘I fear that Marie would not leave.’

49 Interestingly, unlike *fear* predicates, predicates of *desire* like *préférer* ‘prefer’ do not
 50 allow for EXN except when negative *pas* is also present in the embedded clause. This
 51 is shown in (2). While EXN is ungrammatical in (2a) under the intended reading that
 52 Marie would leave, it is optional but grammatical when combined with *pas* in (2b)
 53 with a meaning shift towards the negative. Even though these clauses still come with
 54 morphological subjunctive mood marking, they do not license EXN.

- 55 (2) a. Je préfère que Marie (***ne**) parte.
 56 I prefer that Marie (EXN) leave.SBJV
 57 Int(ended): ‘I prefer that Marie would leave.’
 58 b. Je préfère que Marie (**ne**) parte pas.
 59 I prefer that Marie (EXN) leave.SBJV NEG
 60 ‘I prefer that Marie would not leave.’

¹Unless otherwise indicated, all data presented in this paper are based on the native speaker judgments of the authors, supplemented by informal discussions with other native speakers.

²Glossing follows the Leipzig conventions, with the following addition: EXN *expletive negation*.

³French *ne* can appear in a variety of constructions. It is, for instance, still used as part of the standard negator in formal French (*ne...pas*), but it also occurs in temporal clauses, comparatives, and most notably, *fear*-clauses. In this paper, we solely focus on its distribution in the latter.

59 Similarly, *belief*-predicates like *croire* ‘believe’ and *penser* ‘think’ do not allow for the
60 bare use of *ExN* either, as shown in (3). Additionally, they also bar subjunctive mood
61 in their embedded clauses unlike *fear* and *desire* predicates. Instead, they require the
62 indicative mood.

- 63 (3) a. Je crois que Marie (***ne**) part.
64 I believe that Marie (*ExN*) leave.*IND*
64 Int: ‘I believe/think that Marie is leaving.’
65 b. Je crois que Marie (**ne**) part pas.
65 I believe that Marie (*ExN*) leave.*IND NEG*
66 Int: ‘I believe/think that Marie is not leaving.’

67 These three observations raise several questions. First, what is the function of *ExN*
68 in French in *fear* clauses? Second, what are the particular properties of *fear*-clauses
69 that license *ExN* in French to the exclusion of examples like (2)-(3)? Third, what is
70 the relationship between *ExN* and the morphological mood marking of the embedded
71 predicate in French given that both types of *fear*-clauses are marked subjunctive?
72 Finally, how do we model the semantics of *fear*-clauses and *ExN*?

73 In this paper, we aim to provide an answer to all of these questions, starting with
74 the arguments that *fear*-predicates essentially come in two guises, a cognitive and
75 conative one, and that *ne* is not fully optional, because its presence (or absence) makes
76 a meaningful contribution. In particular, we will propose that when the embedded
77 clause of a *fear*-predicate has *ExN*, *fear* takes up a *belief*-like role, while its absence
78 indicates an emotion of *fear* towards the possible realization of an eventuality. Our
79 analysis is supported by the view that *fear* is not derived from bouletic modality (e.g.,
80 Van der Wouden 1994; Mari and Tahar 2020), meaning that *fears* and *wishes* do not
81 uniformly belong to a single ontological category. *Fears* essentially exhibit scattered
82 ontological behavior, acting both like **beliefs** and **wishes**. This answers the first and
83 the fourth questions.

84 Our proposal takes *ExN* to have a disambiguating role to differentiate conative *fears*
85 from cognitive *fears*. Given that *preferences* are only conative, they are expected to be
86 incompatible with *ExN*. For cognitive attitudes like *beliefs*, the information provided
87 by *ExN* is already part of their lexical meaning. This answers the second question.

88 Finally, we take morphological mood marking to be the result of agreement between
89 the attitudinal object with a specific feature and the embedded predicate. Hence,
90 strictly speaking, the presence of *ExN* in some *fear* clauses and the presence of
91 subjunctive mood is accidental. This answers the third question.

92 The main contributions of this paper are thus (i) the view that *fear*-predicates form
93 their own ontology, separate from beliefs and wishes, (ii) the presentation of novel
94 data and tests to support this view, and (iii) fleshing out the role of *ExN* in French
95 *fear*-clauses.

96 The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 couches the paper within the object based
97 semantics developed for modals and attitudes by Moltmann (2024), and it summarizes

our main proposals for *fear*-clauses and EXN. Section 3 introduces the phenomenon of EXN and presents novel data for French *fear*-clauses and EXN. The observations made in this section enable us to distinguish between two types of *fears*; that is, conative and cognitive, only the latter of which occurs with EXN. Section 4 formalizes these observations and provides a semantic model to account for the properties associated with them, as well as discussing its crosslinguistic predictions. Section 5 is a discussion of the previous work on EXN as compared to our model, and demonstrates the issues of the previous work with respect to the novel data that we provided. Section 6 concludes the paper.

2 Theoretical framework and proposal in a nutshell

In this section, we will discuss the ontology of fears. Following Moltmann’s (2024) claim that attitude predicates introduce attitudinal objects, such as *beliefs*, *hopes*, *wishes* etc.,. We will argue that French *fear*-predicates introduce objects of *fear* and that their ontology is split into cognitive (*belief*-like) and conative (*wish*-like) fears.

Section 2.1 lays out the foundations of *object-based semantics* as developed by Moltmann (2024) and, building on this type of semantics, section 2.2 presents our main proposal for French *fear*-clauses and their interaction with EXN.

2.1 Object based semantics

The object based semantics developed for attitudes takes attitude predicates to be complex syntactic structures that introduce an attitudinal object with a propositional content (Moltmann 2024). This means that a predicate like *believe* is not a relation between an attitude holder and a proposition, unlike what is assumed in the classical Russellian/Fregean treatments of attitudes, but rather describes possession of a belief object with the “satisfaction conditions” described by the embedded clause. In other words, in order for a belief to hold, the embedded proposition must hold as well. Consider, for instance, the sentence in (4a), which has the meaning presented in (4b), where $\equiv$ is an equivalence relation between any two representational objects.⁴ Similarly, a *wish*-clause will introduce an object of *wish* that would come to realization iff the embedded clause came to realization (5).

- (4) a. John believes that Mary loves him.
b. $\exists o[has(j, o) \wedge belief(o) \wedge o \equiv Love(m, j)]$

- (5) a. John wishes that Mary love him.
b. $\exists o[has(j, o) \wedge wish(o) \wedge o \equiv Love(m, j)]$

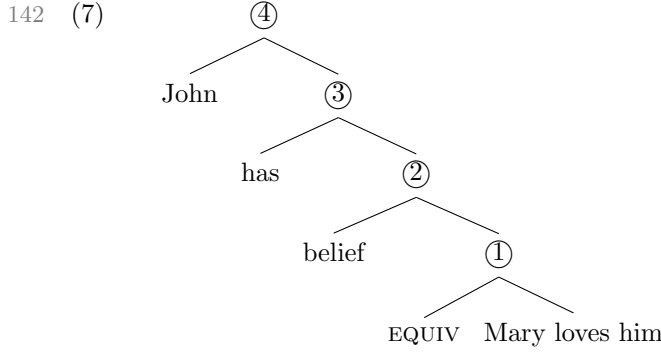
In both cases, the equivalence relationship is to be understood not as ontological equivalence between two representational objects, but as truth conditional equivalence. In

⁴Moltmann (2024) uses a syntactic operation that she calls ‘prop’ in order to represent this verification equivalence, unlike the rendition used in this paper.

133 other words, (4b) states that the belief that John holds has the same truth/satisfac-
 134 tion conditions as the sentence denoted by the embedded clause, namely *that Mary*
 135 *loves him*, as generalized in (6).

136 (6) For any object o and b , $\forall s[s \Vdash o \leftrightarrow s \Vdash b]$

137 Object based semantics of attitude constructions take attitude predicates like *believe*
 138 to be complex syntactic structures corresponding to *have the belief that S*, as in (7).⁵
 139 The syntactic correlate of the satisfaction equivalence between the attitudinal object
 140 and the embedded clause is labeled as EQUIV in (7). The semantic contribution of this
 141 head is provided in (8).



143 (8) $\llbracket \text{EQUIV} \rrbracket = \lambda S. \lambda P. \lambda o. P(o) \wedge o \equiv S$

144 Accordingly, EQUIV combines with a sentence and a predicate of attitudinal objects
 145 of a certain kind to return a predicate of attitudinal objects of the same kind that
 146 are in satisfaction equivalence with the embedded clause. Based on these, we can
 147 compositionally derive the meaning of (7) as in (9).

- 148 (9) a. $\llbracket \text{Mary loves him} \rrbracket = \text{love}(m, j)$
 149 b. $\llbracket \textcircled{2} \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{EQUIV} \rrbracket(\text{love}(m, j))(\llbracket \text{belief} \rrbracket) = \lambda o. \text{belief}(o) \wedge o \equiv \text{love}(m, j)$
 150 c. $\llbracket \text{have} \rrbracket = \lambda P. \lambda x. \lambda o. \text{have}(x, o) \wedge P(o)$
 151 d. $\llbracket \textcircled{4} \rrbracket = \lambda o. \text{have}(j, o) \wedge \text{belief}(o) \wedge o \equiv \text{love}(m, j)$
 152 e. $\exists o : \text{have}(j, o) \wedge \text{belief}(o) \wedge o \equiv \text{love}(m, j)$ ($\exists$ -closure)

153 The object based account of attitude predicates makes use of so-called *truthmaker*
 154 *semantics*, a kind of semantics that has been developed by Fine (2017b) as an alterna-
 155 tive to possible world semantics. According to him, sentence meanings are associated
 156 with states that *exactly* make them true. This exact verification relation is indicated
 157 by the translingual symbol $\Vdash$. In a bilateral system, sentences are also associated

⁵Moltmann (2024) takes *the* to be a weak definite on a par with the existential.

with their falsity-makers. For the sake of simplicity, we will only be interested in sentence verification; hence we will be using a unilateral version of truthmaker semantics throughout the paper (Fine 2017a). However, nothing with overarching consequences hinges on this choice for the current analysis.

Intuitively, truthmakers are entities that have to exist for a given sentence to be true. **Exact** truthmakers are then those entities that are entirely relevant to the truth of the sentence without containing any extra material. Hence, *rain* would be an exact truthmaker for a sentence like *It is raining*, whereas *rain and wind* would only **inexactly** verify this sentence as it contains material irrelevant to the truth of the sentence, namely the wind, (Fine 2017b).

The model in truthmaker semantics corresponds to at least a tuple consisting of a set of (possible) states, and a partial order on them. The verifiers of atomic sentences are directly derived from the model, while complex sentences are defined recursively. Then, given a model M , we can define our verification rules as in (10), where $\perp$ is a primitive exclusive relation between states, and V is the valuation function in the model, (Bernard and Champollion 2024).

- (10) Let $M = \langle S, \sqsubseteq, V \rangle$,
- a. $s \Vdash \neg\varphi \iff \forall s': s' \Vdash \varphi \Rightarrow s \perp s'$
 - b. $s \Vdash \varphi \wedge \psi \iff \exists t, u: s = t \sqcup u \text{ and } t \Vdash \varphi, u \Vdash \psi$
 - c. $s \Vdash \varphi \vee \psi \iff s \Vdash \varphi \text{ or } s \Vdash \psi$
 - d. $s \Vdash \neg(\varphi \wedge \psi) \iff \forall s': s' \Vdash (\varphi \wedge \psi) \Rightarrow s \perp s'$
 - e. $s \Vdash \neg(\varphi \vee \psi) \iff \forall s': s \Vdash (\varphi \vee \psi) \Rightarrow s \perp s'$

(adapted from Fine (2017a))

Although truthmaker states were originally intended to verify sentences, Moltmann (2024) points out that they can in fact verify any (representational) object with a propositional content, be it a *belief*, a *wish* or simply a *sentence*. Accordingly, some representational objects can be verification equivalent although they are ontologically separate objects. For example, a *belief object* and a *sentence* are verification equivalent iff the states that exactly verify the belief also verify the sentence and vice versa.

In this paper, we will also follow Moltmann (2024) is making the assumption that truthmakers can in fact verify objects other than sentences such as *beliefs*, *hopes* or *wishes*. In particular, we will propose that *fears* can be in an exact verification relationship with truthmaking states.

2.2 Our proposal for *fear* and ExN

In the object based semantics for attitudes, propositional attitudes like *beliefs* and *desires* are divided into two major categories: cognitive (*belief*-like) and conative (*wish*-like) types, distinguished by their “direction of fit”. In particular, cognitive attitudes aim to match the mind to the world (mind-to-world), while conative attitudes aim to shape the world to fit the mind (world-to-mind). This distinction is reminiscent

197 of the difference between assertions of declarative clauses and imperatives/subjunc-
 198 tives/commands. These are also characterized based on the fact that the former can
 199 be true/false, whereas the latter can only be satisfied/realized/come true. Moltmann
 200 (2024) uses this distinction to account for the intuitive difference observed between
 201 (4) and (5). Furthermore, she posits that the syntactico-semantic structure of attitude
 202 constructions reflects this similarity. The embedded sentences describing the verifica-
 203 tion conditions for the attitudinal objects belong to the same group as the attitudinal
 204 object: the embedded clause of a *belief* predicate is usually indicative while the embed-
 205 ded clause of a *wish* or *command* is subjunctive, matching in terms of the direction
 206 of fit in languages that morphologically mark the distinction between the two moods
 207 (at least in languages that mark mood in embedded clauses) (see Moltmann 2024 for
 208 more details).

209 While we will largely build on Moltmann’s work, we depart from it in claiming that the
 210 morphological mood present in the embedded predicate is not necessarily the reflex
 211 of this direction of fit requirement imposed by the attitudinal object or the equiva-
 212 lence relationship. For instance, we find that emotive factive predicates, as *regret*, *be*
 213 *happy*, *be surprised*, also take the subjunctive mood in embedded clauses in Romance
 214 languages, even though they are compatible with a mind-to-world direction of fit,
 215 similar to cognitive attitudes. Furthermore, morphological mood selection appears to
 216 be mainly a syntactic phenomenon whereby a particular feature syntactically licenses
 217 its presence (see Section 4). Yet, we keep Moltmann (2024)’s insights regarding the
 218 contribution of the direction of fit, and propose that the direction of fit of a given atti-
 219 tudinal object determines how it is satisfied or more precisely, whether, in a case where
 220 a state that verifies the object obtains in the actual world, the object is *realized* like
 221 *wishes/commands* or is true like *beliefs*. Although we do not in general assume that
 222 the morphological mood is not typically a reflex of the direction of fit for embedded
 223 sentences in Romance, particularly not in French, we will still follow Moltmann (2024)
 224 in that two satisfiable objects will be in satisfaction equivalence iff their direction of
 225 fit also matches.

226 Building on these ideas, we propose that there are two types of *fear* objects: one is
 227 cognitive (f_{cog}), and the other one is conative (f_{con}). In particular, we claim that f_{cog}
 228 is an object of fear that would be true iff the embedded clause is true, whereas f_{con}
 229 would come into being iff the states verifying the embedded clause come into being.
 230 Finally, we show that ExN in the embedded clause marks a “shift” from f_{con} to f_{cog} ,
 231 by marking the direction of fit of the embedded clause as cognitive as opposed to
 232 conative.

233 3 Expletive Negation

234 3.1 What is ExN?

235 In the literature on expletive negation (ExN), at least three distinct conceptual
 236 approaches have been claimed to account for its cross-linguistic behavior. First, ExN
 237 has been argued to be genuinely expletive (empty, or semantically null)—that is, it
 238 has been believed to contribute no semantic content whatsoever (cf. Müller 1978;

239 Espinal 1992, 2000; Larrivée 1994; Brown 1999, among others). Nowadays, this view
 240 is no longer supported by the majority of scholars. Instead some have argued that
 241 EXN is genuinely negative, though potentially in a non-standard way (see Larrivée
 242 1994; Rowlett 1998b; Vogeleer 2001; Cépeda 2018; Cepeda and Déprez 2023; Delfitto
 243 et al. 2019; Delfitto 2020, among others). Or third, that while EXN is non-negative, it
 244 is still semantically meaningful, contributing epistemic modal meaning to the clause
 245 (see Yoon 2011, Makri 2013, 2016; Tsiakmakis and Espinal 2022; Tsiakmakis et al.
 246 2022, among others). One line of analysis argues that in instances of EXN, the negative
 247 morpheme does not fulfill its typical semantic role of expressing negation. Instead, it
 248 is treated as logically vacuous, semantically inert, or redundant. Under this view, the
 249 negative morpheme contributes no negation to the sentence’s interpretation; it has no
 250 effect on the truth conditions or the logical form of the sentence. A second account of
 251 EXN maintains that the negative marker in EXN constructions always expresses nega-
 252 tion, though not the sentential negation. On this view, the negative morpheme retains
 253 a negative semantic contribution, but its function diverges from that of canonical
 254 sentential negation. Crucially, this analysis treats the label “expletive” as purely ter-
 255 minological (Abels 2005), rather than as a descriptive claim about semantic vacuity.
 256 (iii) A third line of analysis argues that the negative morpheme in EXN construc-
 257 tions is not genuinely a negative element. Although it takes the form of a negative
 258 marker, it is semantically non-negative and, in fact, serves an entirely different func-
 259 tion. This view thus distinguishes the morpheme’s morphological appearance from its
 260 semantic role. Under this line of analysis, EXN is thus not negative, but nonetheless
 261 contributes semantic content. Recently, it has been analyzed as epistemic in nature.
 262 One of the arguments in favor of the epistemic meaning of EXN is presented by
 263 Makri (2013, 2016). In Modern Greek (MG), the EXN particle *mi(n)* cannot co-occur
 264 with the epistemic adverb *malon* ‘probably’ (11). Makri takes this incompatibility to
 265 reflect complementary distribution between *malon* and *mi(n)*. When *mi(n)* is absent,
 266 *malon* is acceptable. In this case, *mi(n)* is replaced by *oti*, the standard indicative
 267 complementizer. French is similar to MG in this respect, (12) and so is Czech, (13).

- 268 (11) (Tsiakmakis et al. 2022: 1261, (10))
 269 a. Fovame min (#malon) troi pola ghlika.
 270 fear.1SG MIN probably eat.3SG many sweets
 271 I fear he maybe eats a lot of candy.
 272 b. Fovame oti malon troi pola ghlika.
 273 fear.1SG that probably eat.3SG many sweets
 274 I fear that he maybe eats a lot of candy.
 275
 276 (12) (French)
 277 a. J’ai peur que Marie ne parte (#peut-être).
 278 I-have fear that Marie EXN leave.SBJV perhaps
 279 I’m afraid that Marie will perhaps leave.
 280 b. ?J’ai peur que Mary parte (peut-être).
 281 I-have fear that Marie leave.SBJV perhaps
 282 I’m afraid that Marie will perhaps leave.

- 278 (13) (Czech)
 279 a. Bojím se aby Petr (#možna) nepřišel.
 280 fear-1SG REFL THAT.SBJV Petr maybe EXN-come.PAST
 280 'I fear that Peter will maybe come.'
 281 b. Bojím se že Petr možna přijde.
 281 fear-1SG REFL THAT Peter maybe come.PERF
 282 'I fear that Peter will maybe come.'

283 We have already shown that ExN is non-negative in French, in the example (1). The
 284 examples in (12) shows that ExN closely correlates with epistemicity. In the next
 285 section, we argue that the presence of *ne* makes a shift from conative to cognitive
 286 interpretation of *fear*.

287 3.2 French ExN in *fear*-clauses

288 *Fear*-clauses without ExN in the embedded clause require the attitude holder's belief
 289 towards the possible realization of the eventuality described by the embedded clause. In
 290 contexts where this requirement is violated, regular *fear*-clauses without *ne* are infelic-
 291 itous, as shown in (14). The infelicity of (14b) in the context described in (14a), where
 292 there is the belief only towards the possibility that p, shows that *fear* clauses without
 293 ExN have this requirement. The purpose of (14) is to show the baseline requirement
 294 of *fear*-clauses without the potential contribution of *ne*.⁶

- 295 (14) a. Context: Marie believes that Jean will not come to the party, because he
 296 is on holidays.
 297 b. Marie: #Je crains que Jean vienne ce soir, je l'aime pas
 297 I fear that Jean come.SBJV this night, I him-like NEG
 298 du tout.
 298 of.the all
 299 'I fear that Jean come tonight, I don't like him at all.'

300 In the context described in (14a), Marie has no belief that Jean will go to the party.
 301 In fact, she believes the complete opposite due to information that was available to
 302 her prior. Hence, from the perspective of Marie, there is no possibility that Jean will
 303 come to the party. In this context, Marie cannot felicitously utter the *fear*-clause in
 304 (14b) without *ne*. This shows that *fear* clauses without ExN require at least the belief
 305 towards the possible realization of the embedded clause.

⁶Most of the examples in this paper uses 1SG matrix subjects - generally confounded with the speaker. Note though that our claim(s) also apply to different types of subjects.

(i) Marie craint que Jean (ne) vienne ce soir.
 Marie fears that Jean ExN come.SBJV this evening
 'Marie fears that Jean come tonight.'

306 This fact is further corroborated by the fact that when we modify the context in a way
 307 that opens up the possibility of the embedded clause being realized, the *fear*-clause
 308 without EXN becomes felicitous. This is illustrated in (15).

- 309 (15) a. Context: Marie believes that Jean might come to the party.
 310 b. Marie: Je crains que Jean vienne ce soir, je l'aime pas du
 311 I fear that Jean come.SBJV this night, I him-like NEG of.the
 312 tout.
 all
 'I fear that Jean come tonight, I don't like him at all.'

313 Crucially, the presence of EXN in the embedded clause in (16) makes a meaningful
 314 semantic contribution, as opposed to its absence in (15). In (16a), Marie entertains only
 315 the possibility that John will come to the party, satisfying the possibility requirement
 316 of *fear*-clauses. In this context, the use of EXN is infelicitous, though its absence
 317 prevents ungrammaticality.

- 318 (16) a. Context: Marie believes that Jean might come to the party, but she knows
 319 that it is not certain.
 320 b. #Je crains que Jean **ne** vienne ce soir, il va encore boire et
 321 I fear that Jean EXN come.SBJV this night, he will again drink and
 322 ruin notre soirée.
 ruin our party.
 323 'I fear that Jean will come tonight, he will get drunk again and ruin the
 party.'

324 We take this contrast between (14)-(16) to indicate that the presence of EXN con-
 325 tributes genuinely to the interpretation of *fear*-clauses. Specifically, it requires the
 326 attitude holder's commitment towards the truth of the embedded clause, rather than
 327 merely to its possibility, as opposed to the baseline case in (14).

328 In contrast, when John has the belief towards the truth of the embedded clause, not
 329 just the possibility, *fear*-clauses with *ne* becomes felicitous, as illustrated in (17).

- 330 (17) a. Context: Jean intends to tell Marie that Paul is coming to the party. He
 331 knows that Marie will not like this, because Marie cannot stand Paul :
 332 he drinks a lot and ruin all the parties. John tells Marie:
 333 b. Je crains que Paul **ne** vienne ce soir, je suis désolé....
 334 I fear that Paul EXN come.SBJV this night, I am sorry.
 'I fear that Paul will come tonight, I am sorry.'

335 Aside from this, we observe that *fears* and *wishes* do not uniformly belong to a single
 336 ontological category. When the embedded clause contains EXN, the *fear* is truth-apt
 337 but cannot be realized (see (18a)), much like a *belief* as shown in (18b). Namely, *fears*
 338 with *ne* can be true or false, but cannot *come true or false*.

- 339 (18) a. Jean avait peur qu'un requin **ne** l'attaque, et cette peur était
 340 Jean had fear that.a shark EXN him.attack and this fear was
 341 vraie/#s'est réalisée.
 342 true/is REFL.realized
 343 'Jean feared that a shark would attack him and this fear was true/#came
 344 true.'
 345 b. Jean croyait qu'un requin l'avait attaqué, et cette croyance
 346 Jean believed that.a shark him.attacked, and that belief was
 347 était vraie/#s'est réalisée
 348 true/was realized
 349 John believed that a shark attacked him, and that belief was true/#came
 350 true.

351 Conversely, when the embedded clause lacks EXN, the *fear* is realizable, but not truth-
 352 apt: namely it can come true or false, but cannot be true or false as in (19a), much
 353 like a wish as shown in (19b)

- 354 (19) a. Jean a peur qu'un requin l'attaque, et cette peur s'est
 355 Jean have fear that.a shark him.attack and this fear was
 356 réalisée/#est vrai.
 357 realized
 358 'Jean feared that a shark would attack him and this fear was realized/-
 359 came true.'
 360 b. Jean souhaitait que Marie l'épouse, et cela s'est réalisé/#est vrai.
 361 Jean wished that Marie him.marry and this was realized.
 362 'Jean wished that Marie would marry him, and this was realized/came
 363 true.'

364 The contrasts presented in (18) and (19) show that *fears* can be both truth-apt just
 365 like *beliefs* and realizable just like *wishes*. Then, *fear* objects come in two guises. But
 366 the selection of the *fear* object is not haphazard. In particular, when *exN* is present,
 367 the *fear* object behaves like a *belief* whilst when it is absent, it behaves like a *wish*.

368 Based on these facts, *fears* do not form a uniform class with respect to their *direction*
 369 of fit, and therefore they, at least in a subset of their occurrences, cannot be derived
 370 from *wishes*, or bouletic modality as traditionally proposed (see Van der Wouden 1994,
 Mari and Tahar 2020 for EXN and the discussion in Section 5).

371 Additionally, we observe that any reference to *beliefs* is only possible when the embed-
 372 ded clause has EXN. This shows that *fear*-clauses with *ne* somehow generate an
 373 environment for *belief* reference while whatever is referred to as *belief* in (20b) is
 374 absent in (20a). Since the two sentences minimally differ with respect to whether they
 375 include EXN or not, we conclude that it is *ne* that makes the *belief* reference possible
 376 in (20b).

- 371 (20) a. #Jean avait peur qu'un requin l'attaque mais sa croyance était fausse.
 372 John had fear that.a shark him.attack but his belief was false
 373 'John feared that a shark would attack him, but this belief was false.'
 374 b. Jean avait peur qu'un requin **ne** l'attaque, mais sa croyance était
 375 John had fear that.a shark **ExN** him.attack but his belief was
 fausse.
 false
 'John feared that a shark would attack him but this belief was false.'

376 This contrast is interesting because reference to beliefs is only possible with cogni-
 377 tive attitudes, like *hypotheses*, *thoughts*, *imagination*s, whereas reference to *beliefs*
 378 are barred with conative attitudes, like *wishes*, *commands*, *desires*. This contrast is
 379 illustrated in (21).

- 380 (21) a. John hypothesizes/thinks/imagines/claims that Mary is happy, but this
 381 belief is false.
 382 b. John wishes/wants/desires/demands/commands/requests that Mary be
 383 here, #and that belief is false.

384 Accordingly, we conclude that **ExN** contributes to the interpretation of *fear*-clauses. In
 385 particular, *fears* with *ne* are truth-apt while those without are not. This suggests that
 386 *fears* come in two classes: one type of *fear* is cognitive much like *beliefs*; the other type
 387 is conative similar to *wishes*. Importantly, cognitive *fears* involve *beliefs* towards the
 388 truth of their embedded clauses whereas conative *fears* involve *beliefs* towards their
 389 possibilities only.

390 In the next section, we formalize these properties associated with the two types of *fear*
 391 clauses with and without **ExN**.

392 4 Proposal

393 In this section, we present our ontological assumptions regarding the direction of fit,
 394 and how it differs from the morphological mood observed in French (Section 4.1).
 395 Then, we discuss the semantics of *fear*-clauses in relation to direction of fit (Section
 396 4.2). Additionally, we provide a formal analysis of **ExN** in relation to *fear*-clauses.
 397 Finally, we will present the cross-linguistic implications of our analysis.

398 4.1 Direction of fit and mood

399 The literature on mood selection is quite diverse, and there is currently no consensus
 400 on how it must be best analyzed (either within one language, or cross-linguistically).
 401 This is so partly because the distribution of different moods does not always come with
 402 natural classes of predicates, and perhaps it is not affected by a single parameter, but
 403 might derive from the combination of several factors (see Baunaz & Puskas 2022 for
 404 a recent overview of the semantic and syntactic literature). While subjunctive mood

405 selection in Balkan Languages, for instance, is quite uniform (it is selected by non-
 406 factive *wish*-type of predicates)⁷, it is trickier in Romance. For instance, in French, it
 407 can be selected by non-factive predicates of the conative type (*command*, *wish*) and by
 408 factive verbs of the *emotive* type (*be happy*, *regret*). In addition, some predicates may
 409 also alternate in their mood selection, irrespective of factivity (*remember*, *understand*,
 410 *dream*, a.o).

411 Indeed, because of the difficulty in grouping the environments where subjunctive mood
 412 can occur in French, Schlenker (2008) argues that it is an elsewhere mood, which
 413 is realized when the presupposition of the indicative is not satisfied. He uses Heim
 414 (1982)’s *Maximize Presupposition!* to model the competition between indicative and
 415 subjunctive moods.

416 From a more syntactic point of view, recent work highlights the role of emotive con-
 417 texts in cross-linguistic mood selection, including in French (see Baunaz and Puskás
 418 2022, 2025, in particular). They argue that, with alternating verbs, the subjunctive
 419 is licensed by an emotive feature triggered in such contexts, leading to a preference
 420 for the subjunctive in emotive contexts and the indicative in non-emotive ones.⁸ Con-
 421 versely, verbs that strictly select a single mood remain unaffected. This prediction is
 422 experimentally confirmed by Baunaz et al. (2024).

423 Translating these results to our framework, the subjunctive morphology that we
 424 observe in French embedded clauses is a morphosyntactic reflex of emotivity of the
 425 attitudinal object in question.⁹ Hence, all conative objects are going to be marked
 426 with it, while this type of analysis also predicts some cognitive predicates to be marked
 427 with the subjunctive as long as they have an emotive component.

428 Accordingly then, we need to separate the correlates of cognitive and conative dis-
 429 tinction from the correlates of morphological marking of subjunctive and indicative,
 430 at least in French.

431 We agree with Moltmann (2024) that, in general, mood does not seem to affect the type
 432 of situations that make otherwise identical sentences true. For example, the situations
 433 that exactly verify that *John came* are the same as a command directed towards John
 434 that *he comes*. The verifier sets of the two sentences are the states of John’s coming.
 435 However, based on our previous discussion, we depart from her analysis in that the
 436 morphological reflex of subjunctivity directly correlates with the concept of direction
 437 of fit as hinted at in Section 2.2. We assume that objects come with their direction of
 438 fit ontologically. However, the direction of fit is not necessarily marked as the mood
 439 of a sentence in French (and in Romance, more generally).

⁷These predicates are also referred to as “non-veridical” predicates in Giannakidou’s framework, see Giannakidou 2009; Giannakidou and Mari 2021 and other references cited there.

⁸Drawing on cross-linguistic data involving embedded subjunctive clauses, these authors argue that the emotive component associated with subjunctive mood originates within the lexical structure of predicates that license such clauses. Specifically, this component encodes a desirability-based attitude (which they call ‘emotive’) towards the eventuality described by the embedded clause. The licensing predicates are analyzed as decomposing into a series of hierarchically ordered functional projections, with the highest projection headed by a bouletic operator, realized syntactically via an [emotive] feature. This feature is responsible both for assigning an emotive interpretation to the external argument (as the bearer of an emotion) and for syntactic licensing the embedded subjunctive.

⁹With *emotivity* understood as in Baunaz and Puskás 2022, 2025; see also footnote 8.

Recall that in object-based semantics, attitudinal objects are construed as satisfaction equivalent with their embedded clauses. Furthermore, we assumed that this equivalence is provided by the syntactic head EQUIV. However, this equivalence, by itself, does not specify the direction of fit for the attitudinal object. Rather, in Moltmann (2024)’s framework, the attitudinal object determines the direction of fit as part of their ontological properties. Depending on this, the embedded clause becomes indicative or subjunctive, which generates an ontological matching between the two objects that are in content equivalence in Moltmann (2024)’s framework under the assumption that the morphological mood correlates with the direction of fit.

We agree with Moltmann (2024) that attitudinal objects will determine their direction of fit. However, we leave open the possibility that some predicates in some languages will be lexically underspecified with respect to what type of objects they introduce in terms of their direction of fit. This means that in those cases, other linguistic tools will be made available to determine how to interpret their satisfaction conditions. We propose that *EXN* in French is the specification for the mind-to-world direction of fit for *fear*. This does not imply that *fear* predicates across all languages are underspecified with respect to what type of *fear* they are: English, for instance, seem to specify the type of *fear* with two distinct lexical items (see the discussion in Section 4.3). It only implies that if a lexical item is ambiguous between two types of objects in a given language, then the language might adopt other strategies to disambiguate between them.

Second, even though the direction of fit of embedded clauses must match with the direction of fit of the attitudinal object in question, it is not necessarily specified by their mood. We propose that morphological mood is mainly sensitive to the emotive properties of the attitudinal object in French. For example, factive verbs generally take indicative mood, but when they are *emotive*, they take subjunctive mood in French. In general, attitudinal objects will, in some way, specify the type of equivalence relationship that they carry over to their embedded clauses. The cognitive ones will be equivalent to the embedded clause in a mind-to-world direction of fit, and therefore their satisfaction boils down to their truth-aptness while conative ones will be equivalent to them in world-to-mind direction of fit, hence their satisfaction will amount to their realization/coming true. In other words, our account predicts that the attitudinal objects of emotive factives are semantically marked as cognitively equivalent to their embedded clauses albeit being morphologically marked as subjunctive.

However, since we do not adopt Moltmann (2024)’s strategy to match the direction of fit between two content equivalent objects, we propose that the application of the equivalence relation $\equiv$ introduced in Section 2.1 needs to be restricted to those objects that belong to the same ontological category in terms of their direction of fit. Accordingly, we modify the relation $\equiv$ as in (22).

$$(22) \quad \text{For any two satisfiable objects } d \text{ and } o, d \equiv o \iff fit(d) = fit(o) \wedge \forall s : s \Vdash d \iff s \Vdash o$$

481 The relativize equivalence relation will thus hold only between two objects that that
482 has the same direction of fit.

483 In short, following Baunaz and Puskás (2022, 2025), we propose that morphological
484 marking of subjunctivity is a morpho-syntactic reflex of the presence of emotivity of
485 the attitudinal object in question independent of what type of direction of fit the
486 attitudinal object is specified for. This does not mean that the direction of fit is
487 unrelated to emotivity. All conatives are emotives in that they involve some level
488 of desire towards the accomplishment of an eventuality, i.e., towards the realization
489 of an eventuality. However, truth-bearing sentences might also be associated with
490 desirability as observed with cognitive attitudes like emotive factives.

491 Now that we have laid out our foundational assumptions with respect to the direction
492 of fit, we can model the semantic contribution of *fear*-clauses and EXN in French.

493 4.2 Semantics of *fear* clauses and expletive negation

494 In Section 3, we showed that *fear*-clauses with *ne* can be true or false whereas those
495 without *ne* can only be realized. This behavior observed in embedded clauses of *fear*
496 in French is parallel to the direction of fit associated with matrix clauses of different
497 ‘moods’ as well. Matrix clauses that are formally identical to embedded subjunctives
498 in French have conative direction of fit, i.e., they are not truth-apt but can only
499 come true/realized, while matrix clauses formally identical to indicatives in embedded
500 clauses are truth-apt, but they are not the kind of things that can come true; they
501 simply describe how the world is (Anscombe (1956); Searle (1983) among others). This
502 contrast is presented in (23).

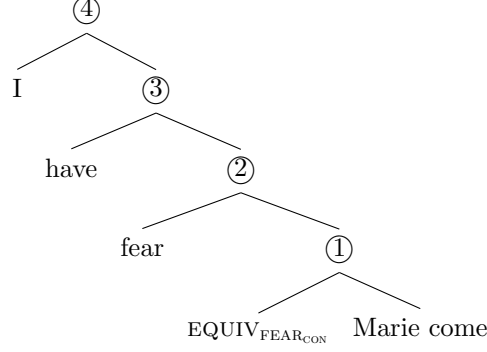
- 503 (23) a. Que la guerre se finisse! Cela doit **devenir une réalité**./#Cela
That the war REF end.SBJV this must become a reality./This
504 sera bientôt **vrai**.
will.be soon true.
505 ≈ ‘May the war end! That must be a reality./This will be true soon.’
506 b. La guerre est finie. Cela est **vrai**.
The war AUX.IND ended. That is true.
507 ‘That the war ended. That is true.’

508 Given that *fear* with EXN possesses several important properties associated with the
509 mind-to-world direction of fit both for embedded and non-embedded clauses, we pro-
510 pose that it marks the direction of fit of *fear* as mind-to-work, making it on a par
511 with *beliefs* as opposed to *desires*.

512 In particular, we propose that there are two types of *fear* in our ontology. One type
513 of *fear* is the conative *fear*, ontologically on a par with *wishes* and *commands*; that
514 is the world must change to fit its content; hence the requirement that its content
515 must be realized/come true for the *fear* to be satisfied. In French, this type of *fear*
516 occurs without the expletive negation in the embedded clause. We will propose that

517 the structure of this type of *fear* involves a modal object, namely a *possibility*, as
 518 shown in (24b)-(24c).

- 519 (24) a. J'ai peur que Marie vienne.
 I.have fear that Marie come.SBJV
 520 'I fear that Marie come.'
 521 b. $\exists o[fear(o) \wedge has(the\ speaker, o)] \wedge \exists p[possibility(p) \wedge o \equiv p \equiv come(m)]$
 522 c. For any two satisfiable object d and o , $d \equiv o \iff fit(d) = fit(o) \wedge \forall s[s \Vdash$
 523 $d \iff s \Vdash o]$
 524 d.



- 525 e. $\llbracket EQUIV_{fear_{con}} \rrbracket = \lambda S. \lambda P. \lambda o. P(o) \wedge \exists p[possibility(p) \wedge o \equiv p \equiv S]$

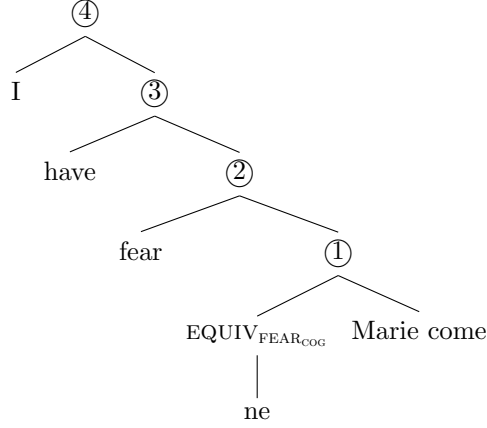
526 This analysis correctly associates the attitudinal object *fear* with conativity. This is
 527 because the fear has the same satisfaction conditions as the modal object of *possibility*.
 528 Since possibilities are only realized or come true, but crucially cannot be true or false,
 529 the satisfaction equivalence would hold only if the fear object is interpreted conatively.
 530 This guarantees that fears without EXN cannot be true or false, but can be realized or
 531 come true.

532 Furthermore, our analysis correctly accounts for the fact that the possession of cona-
 533 tive *fears* are only possible when the holder of *fear* believes in the possibility of the
 534 realization of the embedded clause. This is because the attitude holder has an object
 535 of *fear* that has the same satisfaction conditions as the *possibility that Marie come*.
 536 This means that the attitude holder knows that the states that will realize the *fear*
 537 will also realize the possibility. Hence, the states that verify the embedded clause must
 538 at least be possible states to verify the possibility.

539 The second type of *fear* is cognitive. This type of fear involves the commitment of the
 540 holder of fear towards the truth of the embedded clause, ontologically on a par with
 541 *beliefs*. Accordingly, as cognitive *fear*, its direction of fit is mind-to-world. This means
 542 that its content must match how the world already is, which explains why it has to
 543 be true or false, but crucially it cannot be realized/come true. The logical structure of
 544 sentences involving cognitive *fear* is similar to those involving conative *fear*, with the
 545 exception that the satisfaction equivalence is between an object of *fear* and a *belief*,
 546 hence the difference between how the content of *fear* is satisfied.

547 Differently from the conative *fear*, the cognitive *fear* must occur with *ExN*. Thus, we
 548 propose that *ExN* marks the direction of fit of the object of *fear* as mind-to-world,
 549 effectively disambiguating an otherwise polysemic lexical item, namely *craindre* ‘fear’
 550 in French. Hence, we will take *ExN* to be equivalent to $\text{EQUIV}_{\text{FEAR}_{\text{COG}}}$. We propose that
 551 this is achieved through the intermediacy of the attitudinal object of *belief* introduced
 552 by *ExN*.

- 553 (25) a. J’ai peur que Marie **ne** vienne.
 I.have fear that Marie *ExN* come.SBJV
 554 ‘I fear that Marie comes.’
 555 b. $\exists o[\text{fear}(o) \wedge \text{has}(\text{the speaker}, o)] \wedge \exists b[\text{belief}(b) \wedge o \equiv b \equiv \text{come}(m) \wedge R(o, b)]$
 556 c. For any two attitudinal objects *o* and *b*, $R(o, b)$ iff if an agent *x* has *o*, it
 557 also has *b*.
 558 d. $\llbracket \text{exN} \rrbracket = \lambda S. \lambda P. \lambda o. P(o) \wedge \exists b[\text{belief}(b) \wedge P(o) \wedge o \equiv b \equiv S \wedge R(o, b)]$
 559 e.



560 In (25b), *fear* is introduced to be satisfaction equivalent with an object of *belief*. This
 561 means that the object of *fear* is interpreted cognitively, the same as *beliefs*. Hence, the
 562 *fear* can be true or false as observed before.

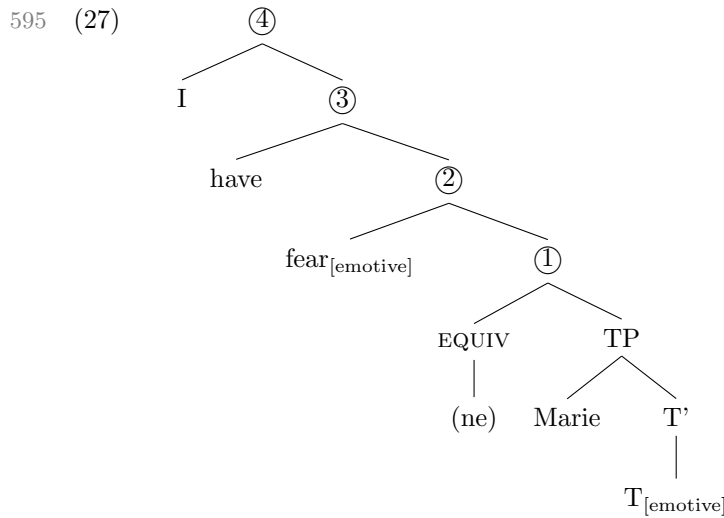
563 This account also makes possible the reference to beliefs. Recall that *fear* clauses with
 564 expletive negation enables continuations that can make explicit reference to *beliefs*.
 565 The relevant example is repeated in (26b). Since *ExN* introduces an object of belief, it
 566 is no surprise that such a reference is possible in *fear* clauses with *ExN*.

- 567 (26) a. #Jean avait peur qu’un requin l’attaque et cette croyance était fausse.
 Jean had fear that.a shark him.attack and this belief was false
 568 ‘Jean feared that a shark would attack him, and this belief was false.’
 569 b. Jean avait peur qu’un requin **ne** l’attaque, et cette croyance était
 Jean had fear that.a shark *ExN* him.attack and this belief was
 570 fausse.
 false
 571 ‘Jean feared that a shark would attack him and this belief was false.’

572 Finally, we can account for why *fear* clauses with *EXN* involves the attitude holder's
 573 commitment towards the truth of the embedded clause. This is because *EXN* specifies
 574 that if an attitude holder has this type of fear, it also has the belief with the same
 575 satisfaction conditions.

576 Hence, French *fear* predicates are underspecified with respect to what type of *fear* they
 577 introduce and therefore the properties of the embedded clause plays a disambiguating
 578 role.

579 Finally we would like to discuss why the embedded clauses of two types of *fear* clauses
 580 are both subjunctive despite one type of fear is ontologically akin to beliefs. Recall
 581 that the same holds also of emotive factive predicates in French (see Section 4.1). For
 582 emotive factives, we made a distinction between morphological subjunctive, that was
 583 the morphosyntactic realization of emotivity, as opposed to world-to-mind direction of
 584 fit, that is a semantic parallel of conativity. Since emotive factives are emotive, they are
 585 morphologically marked as subjunctives, just as the two types of *fear* clauses, involving
 586 emotivity, are morphosyntactically marked with subjunctive, while they differ from
 587 each other how they are satisfaction equivalent with the embedded clauses. The latter
 588 is where the contribution of *ne* is. In other words, that is why we see *ne* to mark
 589 the cognitive equivalence to introduce the cognitive *fear* while the predicate is also
 590 morphologically marked subjunctive. Hence, the idea is that attitudinal objects that
 591 have emotive components will have a syntactic features that agrees with the embedded
 592 predicate, marking them as subjunctive as illustrated in (27). Here, we take emotivity
 593 to be a primitive feature of attitudinal objects that involves some degree of positive
 594 or negative stance towards the truth/realization of a given state.



596 4.3 Cross-linguistic predictions

597 Our account of French *ne* also makes cross-linguistic predictions. For one, it raises
 598 the expectation that there are other languages where there is a single lexical item for
 599 *fear* that introduces both objects of *fear*, the properties of the embedded clause must
 600 play a role in the disambiguation between the two. This prediction is borne out for
 601 at least Turkish. Turkish lacks ExN in *fear* clauses. However, it does have a way to
 602 disambiguate between the two *fears* via different types of nominalizations.

603 In Turkish, the default embedded clause of a conative predicate takes the shape of a
 604 *-mA* nominalization, (Kornfilt and Whitman 2011; Demirok 2018), as shown in (28a).
 605 The so-called “future oriented indicative” nominalization, *-(y)AcAK*, is ungrammatical
 606 with it as in (28b).

- 607 (28) a. Can Ali-nin gel-**me**-sin-i iste-di/emret-ti.
 Can Ali-GEN come-MA-POSS-ACC want-PST/command-PST
 ‘Can wished/commanded that Ali come.’
 608
 609 b. *Can Ali-nin gel-**eceğ**-in-i iste-di/emret-ti.
 Can Ali-GEN come-(Y)ACAK-POSS-ACC want-PST/command-PST
 610 Int: ‘Can wished/commanded that Ali come.’

611 In contrast, cognitive attitudes like *beliefs* or *hypotheses* can co-occur with *-(y)AcAK*
 612 clauses as shown in (29b), but they are, in turn, ungrammatical with *-mA* nominal-
 613 izations, (29a).

- 614 (29) a. *Can Ali-nin gel-me-sin-i düşün-dü/varsay-dı/zannet-ti.
 Can Ali-GEN come-MA-POSS-ACC believe-PST/assume-PST/think-PST
 615 Int: ‘Can believed/assumed/thought that Ali came.’
 616 b. Can Ali-nin gel-eceğ-in-i düşün-dü/varsay-dı/zannet-ti.
 Can Ali-GEN come-(Y)ACAK-POSS-ACC
 617 düşün-dü/varsay-dı/zannet-ti.
 believe-PST/assume-PST/think-PST
 618 Int: ‘Can believed/assumed/thought that Ali would come.’

619 Interestingly, the *fear* verb *kork/endişelen* ‘fear/worry’ in Turkish can combine with
 620 both *-mA* and *-(y)AcAK* nominalizations. *Fear*-clauses with *-mA* nominalizations are
 621 conative with a belief towards only the possibility of the embedded clause, as exempli-
 622 fied in (30b), whereas *fear*-clauses with *-(y)AcAK* are cognitive with a belief towards
 623 the truth of the embedded clause, as suggested by the infelicity of (30c), as the holder
 624 of *fear* does not have the belief towards the truth of the embedded clause.

- 625 (30) a. Context: Ali is an absent minded person. As he goes abroad tomorrow,
 626 Can fears that he might lose his phone there, but this is not certain.

- 627 b. Can Ali-nin telefon-un-u kaybet-me-sin-den kork-uyor/endişe
 Can Ali-GEN phone-POSS-ACC lose-MA-POSS-ABL fear-PROG/worry
 628 ed-iyor.
 do-PROG
 629 ‘Can fears/worries that Ali (might) lose his phone.’
 630 c. #Can Ali-nin telefon-un-u kaybed-eceğ-in-den
 Can Ali-GEN phone-POSS-ACC lose-(Y)ACAk-POSS-ABL
 631 kork-uyor/endişe ed-iyor.
 fear-PROG/worry do-PROG
 632 ‘Can is afraid/worries that Ali will lose his phone.’

633 In contrast, when the holder of the *fear* has a belief towards the truth of the embedded
 634 clause, the *fear* clause with *-(y)AcAk* nominalization is acceptable as illustrated in
 635 (31).

- 636 (31) a. Context: Can is sure that Ali will lose his phone when he goes abroad as
 637 he always does.
 638 b. Can Ali-nin telefon-un-u kaybed-eceğ-in-den
 Can Ali-GEN phone-POSS-ACC lose-(Y)ACAk-POSS-ABL
 639 kork-uyor/endişe ed-iyor.
 fear-PROG/worry do-PROG
 640 ‘Can is afraid/worries that Ali will lose his phone.’

641 Hence, in our account, *-mA* nominalizations occur with the conative *fear* with the
 642 belief towards the possibility of the embedded clause, while *-(y)AcAk* clauses occur
 643 with the cognitive *fear* with belief towards the truth of the embedded clause.

644 A second prediction of our analysis is that if there are two types of *fears* ontologically,
 645 then we must find languages where these *fears* are realized differently. English supports
 646 our second prediction. English has at least two predicates of *fear*: one is *fear*, the other
 647 is *be afraid*. In contexts where there is a belief towards the possibility only, *fear* is
 648 considered more acceptable than *be afraid*, as shown in (32).¹⁰

- 649 (32) a. Context: Alex is concerned that their parent might have seen them with
 650 their partner. However, there’s a possibility the parent mistook them for
 651 someone else.
 652 (i) I fear that my parent saw me with my partner.
 653 (ii) ??I am afraid that my parent saw me with my partner.

654 This is in contrast to contexts where the attitude holder has a belief towards the truth
 655 of the embedded clause. In this case, *be afraid* is perfectly acceptable as shown in (33).

- 656 (33) a. Context: Alex believes that their parent saw them with their partner.

¹⁰English can only partially support our second prediction in that the example in (32a-ii) is not infelicitous or ungrammatical, but relatively more degraded.

657 b. I am afraid that my parent saw me with my partner.

658 What this section showed is that our analysis of *fear* as ontologically involving two
659 types of *fear* objects is supported by crosslinguistic data. One type of support is
660 syntactic (as shown with Turkish), and the other type is lexical (as shown with
661 English).

662 5 Previous work and its shortcomings

663 Previous work on *fear* predicates in relation to expletive negation in (the history of)
664 French took several routes. One prominent analysis of them is Mari and Tahar (2020),
665 who investigate expletive and prohibitive negation, focusing on the Latin particle *ne*
666 and its diachronic evolution into Modern French. The authors argue for a unified
667 semantic analysis that explains how *ne* functions differently depending on its syntactic
668 and modal context. In particular, in positive priority and prohibitive contexts, *ne* acts
669 as a true negation in Latin as shown in (34).

- 670 (34) a. Nimium est! Ne clama.
 excess.ACC is NEG₂ shout.2SG.IMP
671 ‘That’s too much! – Don’t shout.’ (Ter, Ph, 664)
672 b. Impero ne clama.
 command.PRES.1.SG NEG₂ call.2.SG.IMP
673 ‘I order you not to shout.’ (Mari and Tahar 2020:59)

674 (34a) is a regular negative imperative whereas (34b) involves a positive priority atti-
675 tude, i.e., the embedded clause, namely that you do not shout conforms to the
676 laws/commands. In negative priority attitudes, however, the embedded clause does
677 not conform to the rules/commands etc. For example, in (35), that you shout is not
678 conform to the laws determined by the speaker.

- 679 (35) Prohibeo ne clama.
 forbid.PRES.1.SG NEG₂ call.2.SG.IMP
680 ‘I forbid you to shout.’ (Mari and Tahar 2020:60)

681 Notice that in positive priority attitudes, the negation has the usual contribution
682 whereas in negative priority attitudes, it does not seem to make any contribution. In
683 (35), the speaker forbids the address to shout, but crucially not to *not shout*. Similarly,
684 in (36), the speaker fears that somebody might have heard them, not that somebody
685 might not have heard them.

- 686 (36) Je crains qu’ on **ne nous** ait entendu.
 I fear that 3.SG.CL ne 2.PL.CL have.3.SG.SUBJ heard
687 ‘I fear that someone heard what we were saying. (Mari and Tahar 2020:56)

688 According to Mari and Tahar (2020), the expletive negation is actually part of the
689 structure of all negative priority attitudes, whether it is overtly spelled out or not.
690 Surely, this analysis is elegant in that the expletive negator is part of the semantics
691 of the verb *fear*, as derived from the same mechanisms to derive *wishes*, with the
692 addition of the negator. However, we have shown that the presence of absence of
693 ExN makes a meaningful contribution to *fear*-clauses. Recall that the presence of
694 ExN in the embedded clauses makes *fear* truth evaluable, rather than something to
695 be realized/that would come true. Additionally, we showed that the presence of *ne*
696 makes the whole *fear* clause infelicitous in contexts where there is no belief towards
697 the necessity of the embedded clause. Accordingly, we believe that the contribution
698 of ExN cannot be reduced to a system where it is always part of the structure of *fear*,
699 but optionally phonologically null.

700 Another prominent analysis of *fear*-predicates in French is offered by Tahar (2021).
701 Her account builds on Anand and Hacquard (2013), who analyse *fear* verbs as hybrid
702 attitude predicates, comprising both a doxastic and a (dis)preferential component.
703 Tahar proposes that *craindre* can give rise to different types of interpretation, depend-
704 ing on whether the expression of dispreference or (dis)belief is part of the assertion or
705 the presupposition.

706 According to her analysis, *craindre* receives a psychological (inquisitive) reading when
707 it appears with a tensed clauses that lacks ExN. In this reading, the assertoric content
708 of a *craindre* clause is a *belief* in the possibility of the embedded clause whereas the
709 dispreference reading is presupposed.

- 710 (37) Psychological (Inquisitive)
711 **Assertion:** $\exists w' \in \text{Dox}(a, w)$ such that *p* is true in w' (There is a belief-world
712 of a where p is true.)
713 **Presupposition:** $\forall w' \in \text{Bul}(a, w) : \neg p$ is true in w' (In all preference worlds,
714 not- p holds.) (Tahar 2021:299)

715 The second reading, namely the admonitive reading, expresses a warning or advice
716 against an undesired but possible event. In this case, *ne* will appear. Its presence in the
717 complement of *craindre* serves to highlight the verb's dispreference component. The
718 admonitive reading is when the contribution of *ne* seems to be semantically present
719 whether it is phonologically present or not. This is similar to the claim made in Mari
720 and Tahar (2020).

- 721 (38) Admonitive
722 **Assertion:** $\forall w' \in \text{Bul}(a, w) : \neg p$ is true
723 (In all preference worlds, not- p holds.)
724 **Presupposition:** $\exists w' \in \text{Dox}(a, w) : p$ is true (a believes p is possible.) (Tahar
725 2021:298)

726 The final reading associated with *craindre* is what she calls “reprehensive”. In this
 727 reading, the assertion is preference for not p with the presupposition of the full belief
 728 towards p. *Ne* may be present in this reading as well.

- 729 (39) Reprehensive
 730 **Assertion:** $\forall w' \in Bul(a, w) : \neg p \text{ is true}$ (In all preference worlds, not-p
 731 holds.)
 732 **Presupposition:** $\forall w' \in Dox(a, w) : p \text{ is true}$ (In all belief worlds, p is true.)
 733 (Tahar 2021:300)

734 Although this analysis derives different readings through shifting combinations of
 735 assertion and presupposition, we identify several problems. First, Tahar claims that in
 736 admonitive readings, *belief* in the possibility of p is presupposed while dispreference is
 737 asserted, and that expletive *ne* signals this structure. However, in contexts where the
 738 speaker clearly believes p is possible (but not certain), *ne* is infelicitous. This contra-
 739 dicts her prediction: *belief* in the possibility of p should suffice to license *ne*, but our
 740 example in (40b) shows it does not.

- 741 (40) a. Context: Marie believes that John might come to the party, but she knows
 742 that it is not certain, and she fears that because he gets drunk easily.
 743 b. #Je crains que Jean ne vienne ce soir, il va encore boire et
 744 I fear that Jean EXN come.SBJV this night, he will again drink and
 745 ruin our party.
 746 ‘I fear that Jean will come tonight, he will get drunk again and ruin the
 party.’

747 Additionally, Tahar (2021) proposes that the different readings associated with
 748 *craindre* results from how its two components, namely the doxastic and bouletic com-
 749 ponents, are combined depending on what content is backgrounded (presupposed)
 750 and what is foregrounded (asserted). While the bouletic component is assertoric in
 751 admonitive and reprehensive readings, it is part of the presupposition in the inquisitive
 752 one, where the doxastic component is asserted. In contrast, the doxastic component
 753 is presupposed in admonitive and reprehensive readings.

754 From a compositional semantics viewpoint, it is unclear how the presuppositional con-
 755 tent of a single lexical item, that is *craindre*, can shift so dramatically across contexts.
 756 While presuppositions may sometimes be backgrounded or promoted to assertions,
 757 it is not evident how one component (e.g., dispreference) can replace another (e.g.,
 758 belief) as the presupposed content.

759 Finally, it is not clear to us that the admonitive and reprehensive readings should
 760 be treated as semantically distinct. Their assertoric content is identical (dispreference
 761 for p), and the difference lies only in the strength of the belief presupposition. Since
 762 the reprehensive reading entails the presupposition of the admonitive one, all contexts
 763 licensing the former should also license the latter. This raises the question: are these

764 truly distinct readings encoded in the semantics of *craindre*, or contextually enriched
765 interpretations of a single modal structure?

766 Unlike Tahar’s account, our analysis ties the distribution of EXN to a principled dis-
767 tinction between cognitive and conative fear, capturing the observed variation without
768 requiring assertion–presupposition shifts.

769 6 Conclusion

770 In this paper, we investigated the distribution of EXN in French *fear* clauses. Our main
771 contribution is an enrichment of the ontology of attitudes of fears. Specifically, we
772 showed that objects of *fear* constitute two distinct categories: cognitive and conative
773 ones. Cognitive fears are more like beliefs in terms of their direction of fit, i.e., how
774 they are satisfied. This means that they can be true or false. Conative fears are like
775 wishes and commands in terms of their direction of fit. This means that they can only
776 be realized/come true and have no truth conditions since they cannot be true or false.
777 This ontological categorization naturally accounts for why some *fear* sentences can be
778 true/false while some others can only be realized/come true.

779 We further claimed that French *fear* verbs can in principle introduce either one of these
780 *fear* objects. However, we claimed that the syntactic structure of the embedded
781 clause helps determine which type of *fear* object is chosen. In particular, we proposed
782 that it is EXN in French which marks the direction of fit of the object of *fear* cognitive
783 by introducing an object of *fear* that is in satisfaction equivalence between the *belief*
784 and *fear*. This accounts for why *fears* with EXN can be true or false, or why it is possible
785 to make reference to beliefs with them. how the embedded clause is satisfied. Since
786 satisfaction equivalent objects must match in terms of the way they are satisfied, the
787 use of EXN embedded under *fear* in French signals that the type of fear introduced is
788 a cognitive one.

789 This proposal had two main cross-linguistic implications: one is the potentially dif-
790 ferent lexicalizations of *fear* objects. We have seen this in English *fear* and *be afraid*.
791 Second implication is that we predict other languages to show similar structural dif-
792 ferentiation in the embedded clauses under *fear*. We have observed that Turkish uses
793 different types of nominalizations depending on the type of *fear* that is introduced.

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